

## PERSONAL INFO



## Charlese Adriana Saballe

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## PROFILE

User Research Lead with 15+ years of experience across user research, data analytics, and workforce management, including 6+ years dedicated to research in games, e-commerce, and consumer tech. I lead player research for Merge Mansion at Metacore (€600M+ lifetime revenue, 60M+ downloads), shaping decisions from early concept and live-ops through to brand strategy and long-term direction.

I combine quantitative rigor with qualitative depth and empathy, and I work comfortably in ambiguity, forming clear points of view that help teams move with confidence. I line-manage and develop researchers, coach designers across the studio, and act as AI champion for the research craft.

Beyond research, I am deeply committed to Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Belonging as a volunteer and community organiser in human rights, LGBTQIA+, and anti-racism advocacy. I stay engaged with the global research and design community through speaking, mentoring, and contributing to industry and grassroots initiatives.

## CORE COMPETENCIES

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|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Quantitative Research</b>                   | Surveys, MaxDiff, Conjoint, beta testing, cluster analysis and segmentation, classification modelling, statistical analysis.                                         |
| <b>Qualitative &amp; Mixed-Method Research</b> | Playtesting, interviews, usability and concept testing, heuristic evaluation, personas, data triangulation.                                                          |
| <b>Strategy &amp; Research Operations</b>      | Competitor and market analysis, brand health tracking, player segmentation, insights repositories, panel and vendor management, research roadmap and resourcing.     |
| <b>Leadership &amp; Collaboration</b>          | Line management, mentoring, career development, stakeholder management at senior leadership level, workshops, AI-assisted workflows                                  |
| <b>Tools</b>                                   | Python, R, SQL, Notion, Qualtrics, Sawtooth, SurveyMonkey, Google Workspace, GameRefinery, Sensor Tower, Miro, FigJam, Claude, PlaytestCloud, UserTesting, Dovetail. |
| <b>Domains</b>                                 | Gaming, e-Commerce, Consumer Tech, Start-ups, DE&I, Civic Organisations.                                                                                             |
| <b>Languages</b>                               | Filipino Native<br>English Near native (IELTS Test: 8.5, Level C2)<br>Finnish Good (YKI Test: Speaking Level 3/B1, Writing Level 4/B2)                               |

## PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

|                               |                                                                                               |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| November 2025 to present      | <b>UX &amp; Player Research Lead</b> ( <i>Acting initially, formal promotion April 2026</i> ) |
| October 2023 to November 2025 | <b>Senior UX and Player Researcher</b><br><b>Metacore Games Oy, Helsinki, Finland</b>         |

Lead player research for Merge Mansion (€600M+ lifetime revenue, 60M+ downloads). Built the function from zero. Partner with design, product, brand, analytics, and leadership across the full game lifecycle.

- Built the player research function from zero, including research intake, roadmap, and insights repository, now embedded in live-ops, feature development, and long-term strategy across the studio.
- Set strategic direction for player research at Metacore, partnering with leadership on prioritisation, resourcing, and team growth.
- Line manage and develop a direct report; scale craft and capacity across the function.

- Design and execute mixed-method research from concept exploration through post-launch live-ops, including player personas, player satisfaction tracking, churn research, brand health, and competitor and market analysis.
- Strategic research partner to senior leadership and cross-functional teams; synthesise complex findings into clear narratives that feed feature prioritisation, event tuning, brand decisions, and long-term content direction.
- Own research operations end-to-end: documentation, templates, guidelines, recruitment, tooling, insights repository, and vendor management.
- Coach designers in research techniques, scaling craft capability across the studio.

#### *Achievements and Impact*

- **Strategic research influence:** Brand Health study findings became the evidence base for a major brand initiative, and player research recommendations were adopted into the direction of the company's top-priority modernisation work.
- **Economy and retention:** Area Satisfaction and Churn research drove rebalancing across 8 in-game areas, reducing friction, restoring flow, and making it easier for lapsed players to return. Milestone area: area churn down ~22%, with a measurable lift in area satisfaction and monetisation.
- **Evidence-based decision-making:** Ran player research alongside the late-areas A/B test, surfacing the disconnect between perceived difficulty improvements and actual satisfaction. Findings informed the decision to revert the change.
- **Feature development:** Research informed the Display Task on Board redesign, a major UI shift bringing tasks onto the main board for the first time, with gains in early-player retention (d7 retention +6% for new players) and goal completion.
- **AI in research practice:** Research-craft AI champion. Built a Notion-based insights repository optimised for AI retrieval using the Atomic Research framework, enabling cross-functional teams to query past research and self-serve answers.
- **Operations and tooling:** Run ~2 studies per month; introduced new survey tooling unlocking MaxDiff and Conjoint analyses;
- **DE&I:** Member of Metacore's DE&I committee; drafted the inclusive design lens for game development, a practical framework for building DE&I into the player experience.

July 2021 to September 2023

### Senior Quantitative User Researcher

January 2021 to July 2021

### Quantitative User Researcher

*Zalando Finland Oy, Helsinki, Finland*

August 2019 to January 2021

### Quantitative User Researcher

*Zalando SE, Berlin, Germany*

Led large-scale consumer research across multiple product verticals, markets, and user segments, generating insights to inform product and portfolio strategy.

- Designed and led end-to-end quantitative and mixed-method research (beta testing, segmentation, experience evaluation), guiding product decisions and launches across multiple teams.
- Managed research intake and recruitment across teams, defining sampling strategies and prioritising incoming requests.
- Delivered User Research Basics, and Statistics for UX trainings, raising research literacy across colleagues and stakeholders.
- Hired, onboarded, and supervised two Research Operations Coordinators (working students).
- Mentored Qualitative User Researchers in quantitative research techniques.

#### *Achievements and Impact*

- **AI in e-commerce (2023):** Led concept testing for the Zalando Assistant, an AI-powered conversational commerce experience novel to the category at launch.
- **Inclusion-driven strategy:** D&I research insights contributed to Zalando onboarding 70+ Black-owned brands in fashion and beauty.
- **Sustainability:** Launched a research on sustainability communication with brand partners and industry groups, contributing to industry standard development and strengthening Zalando's position as a category leader.
- **Beta testing:** Guided go-live decisions for 5 major product initiatives at Zalando.
- **Beauty segmentation:** Identified and established Zalando's Beauty customer segments, which became the foundation for category-level strategy.
- **Research operations:** Built and scaled the internal research panel to 9 markets with 12,000+ members. Established an accessibility panel of 100+ individuals with disabilities. Optimised participant recruitment, cutting cost by 69% and lifting project capacity from 20 to 30 annually.

- March 2017 to July 2017 **Data Analyst**  
*Parkkisähkö Oy, Helsinki, Finland*  
Established and developed reporting and analytics requirements, providing regular data analysis and insights on customer segmentation, utilisation, and demand statistics.
- April 2008 to January 2015 **Senior Analyst, Global Resource Planning**  
*Sykes Enterprises Inc. (through Sykes Asia Inc.), Manila, Philippines*  
Served as a level 2 point of contact for resource planning, offering workforce management consultations to clients. Analysed historical and actual arrival patterns to inform resource strategy decisions. Initiated process improvement initiatives. Trained new analysts.
- June 2007 to April 2008 **Workforce Officer, Workforce Optimization Team**  
*Sykes Asia Inc., Manila, Philippines*  
Maintained staffing line and scheduling indices, optimising employee schedules for efficient workforce management.
- May 2004 to June 2007 **Senior Reports Analyst, Business Management Team**  
*Sykes Asia Inc., Manila, Philippines*  
Managed real-time management operations and analysed reports, identifying trends in KPIs for Microsoft Lines of Business. Investigated data for performance improvement opportunities and provided recommendations. Awarded Best Reports Analyst in 2006.

## EDUCATION

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- 2021 – 2022 **Masters Specialisation Studies in Big Data Analytics (15 ECTS)**  
*Arcada University of Applied Sciences, Helsinki, Finland*
- 2017 – 2019 **Bachelor of Business Administration, Business Information Technology**  
*Haaga-Helia University of Applied Sciences, Helsinki, Finland*  
*Specialisation:* Digital Service Design (User Experience) and Software Development  
*Thesis:* Using Machine Learning Models to Predict the Study Path Selection of Business Information Technology Students
- 1999 – 2004 **Bachelor of Science in Statistics**  
*University of the Philippines, Diliman, Quezon City, Philippines*

## TRAININGS AND CERTIFICATIONS

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- May 2025 **Choice Modeling Master Class: Conjoint Analysis and MaxDiff Methods to Prioritize Customer Needs**  
*Quant UX Association*
- January 2021 **How to Interpret UX Numbers: Statistics for UX**  
*Nielsen Norman Group*

## SPEAKING AND INDUSTRY ENGAGEMENTS

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- December 2025 **Finnish Game Industry DEI Summit, Helsinki**  
*Moderator:* Facilitated two roundtable discussions on anti-racism, and advancing inclusion and safety for transgender people within the games industry.
- October 2025 **Designing With Ears Open: Listen To Your Players, Pocket Gamer Connects Helsinki**  
*Panel Speaker:* Shared about what “listening to players” means at Metacore, highlighting the value of combining different types of data and approaching player feedback with empathy.
- June 2025 **Career Pivots and Cultural Shifts: A Migrant’s Journey into Tech & Games, Womenize! Berlin**  
*Speaker:* Talked about navigating career changes and cultural transitions, and finding a niche and using your voice to uplift others while building a career in tech and games.
- April 2024 **When To Say No: Setting Boundaries At Work**  
*Panel Speaker:* Spoke on boundary-setting and saying no as a strategic act of empowerment for migrant women in tech and gaming.

- September 2021 **Numbers behind the scene: quantitative research in practice, UXHel**  
**Speaker:** Shared about the impact of data on design decisions and foundational steps to establishing UX quantitative research, including creating a scalable research panel.
- August 2017 to April 2018 **PowerCards, Elsevier Global Incubation Programme 2018 and Elsevier Hacks 2017, Helsinki, Finland (3<sup>rd</sup> place)**  
**Researcher, Designer:** Facilitated the whole design process, led user research, designed prototype, created storyboard and process flow and helped in the presentation and pitch
- June 2017 **UXHel Designing Smarter Cities, Espoo, Finland - (Winner)**  
**Designer:** Collaborated in the design process, built the wireframe and prototype and participated in the pitch.

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## COMMUNITY AND LEADERSHIP

- July 2025 - present **Member, AI & Digital Rights Working Group, European Network Against Racism**
- February 2025 - present **Secretary, Anti-Racist Forum, Helsinki, Finland**
- August 2024 - present **Member & Mentor, We in Games Finland, Helsinki, Finland**
- October 2018 to May 2019 **Course Assistant, UX and Prototyping of Digital Services, Haaga-Helia UAS**
- November 2016 - March 2019 **Executive Board Member, ILGA World**

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## PUBLICATIONS

- January 2022 **Machine Learning Models to Predict Students' Study Path Selection**  
**Published Paper**, *International Journal of Interactive Mobile Technologies*
- July 2018 **Experience Changes the Perception and Feelings: A Case Study on MVR Application in Educational Context**  
**Conference Paper**, *10th International Conference on Education and New Learning Technologies (EDULearn2018), Palma, Spain*
- September 2015 **Transrespect versus Transphobia: The Experiences of Trans People in the Philippines**  
**Research Publication**, *STRAP and Transgender Europe, Berlin, Germany*